VU VRIJE UNIVERSITEIT AMSTERDAM

Faculty of Humanities

Course Guide

Digital Humanities

Course code:	L_AAMPALG017
Academic year:	2025-2026
Period:	5
ReMA:	Research Master Humanities
Course Coordinator:	Dr Lorella Viola (History)
Lecturers:	Dr Lorella Viola (History)
	Dr Dries Daems (Archeology)

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General information

Course name:	Digital Humanities
Course code:	L_AAMPALG017
Coordinator:	Dr Lorella Viola
Lecturers:	Dr Lorella Viola and Dr Dries Daems
Period:	Period 5
Credits:	6.0 ECTS
Language:	English
Faculty:	Faculty of Humanities
Class attendance:	Mandatory
Assessment:	Team project portfolio (40%) + Critical reflection, Participation & engagement (60%)
Timetable:	see rooster.vu.nl or vurooster.nl for latest version

Course content

This course gets students acquainted with Digital Humanities (DH), a field that explores the intersection of digital technology and the humanities and interprets digital interactions and relationships of people, topics, ideas, and content. The course provides students with the theory, tools, and methods needed to analyze and interpret digital data in the humanities. It focuses on three main themes:

1. Debates in Digital Humanities
2. Computation & the Humanities: components and workflows
3. Digital methods

Students will engage in critical discussions and hands-on projects that expose them to the practical challenges and opportunities of building a DH workflow as well as theoretical questions within the field of Digital Humanities.

Digital Humanities

The escalating increase in digital material paired with the fast-changing technological landscape demand for a continuous update of research methods and paradigms as well as a combination of theories and methodologies –rather than one single analytical framework – for understanding the social practices associated with human behavior and (digital) communication. Digital Humanities (DH) is a relatively new field of study and research that applies computational methods to (digital) humanities sources to answer humanities questions. It provides humanities scholars with a more elaborate constellation of methods and theories than traditional humanities scholarship to navigate the complexity of digital sources. DH encompasses all fields within the humanities and so DH scholars can for example be historians, linguists, philosophers, or anthropologists.

Even though DH typically requires strong computer skills, there are tools available that do not necessitate extensive prior technical knowledge, which will be one of the foci of this course. The course Digital Humanities will introduce students to the theory and history of this interdisciplinary research field; they will learn how to design, develop, and present a

digital humanities project workflow, and the challenges and opportunities of digital research.

Workflows

The components of a digital humanities project workflow involve methods that are likely to be unfamiliar to traditional humanists. The navigation through the various elements of a digital humanities workflow indeed necessitates a delicate equilibrium between practical applications and critical understanding. Students will learn for example that comprehensive documentation is a critical aspect of ethical research practices in digital humanities, enabling others to retrace the decision-making journey that sculpted their project. At the same time, students will learn that the approaches used to render materials in digital form have impacts and consequences, just as a researcher's application of procedures influences the interpretation of outcomes.

Overall, students will mix experiential learning, practical guidance on digital humanities execution, and analytical scrutiny at every stage of a workflow –mediation, modelling, processing/analytics, presentation, sustainability –to ensure that the core values and methodologies of the humanities are integrated into technology-centric pursuits. Students will gain fluency not only in the theoretical debates surrounding DH such as ambiguity, uncertainty, privacy, ethics, diversity, sustainability, but also in the usage of current methods in DH scholarship.

Interdisciplinary collaboration

In this course, students' diversity is a resource that gives them a chance to learn from and with each other. Students mostly work in groups; in this way, they develop understanding of the value of collaboration in DH research setting whilst becoming acquainted with DH professional practices where collaboration is the norm. Thanks to this combination, students develop greater self-awareness, including awareness of their own function in their social groupings, their own cultural values and the influence of those values upon their attitudes towards "difference". Through practical and critical exercises that are embedded into the curriculum, classroom dynamics that permit dialogue are favoured. This unique set-up encourages learners to think about the class as a community and it helps them improve communication skills that will be essential in their educational and professional future.

Learning objectives (LOs)

Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. Understand and articulate the key issues and debates in digital humanities, especially concerning cultural heritage, digital methods, and the reliability of digital research (LO1);
2. Critically evaluate digital tools, data, and methodologies used in DH research (LO2);
3. Apply digital tools to analyze humanities data, acknowledging the potential for bias and error (LO3);

4. Demonstrate an ability to manage digital projects and create a digital humanities workflows, from data acquisition to dissemination of results (LO4);
5. Collaborate effectively in interdisciplinary teams to conduct digital humanities research (LO5).

Practical matters

Teaching methods
Coursework will include weekly student-led discussions and presentations, and hands-on practical work.
Preparation for the lectures will consist of readings and presentation assignments.
Preparation for the seminars/labs involves hands-on class assignments and tutorials.

It is possible to schedule both individual and group appointments. These meetings can be online as well as on campus. Go to Book time with Viola, L. (Lorella) to schedule your meeting: 15 minutes for individual students, 30 minutes for groups. The instructor may also request a meeting with students. Students are advised to study at the VU on consultation days. For appointments with Dr Daems, please contact him directly at d.daems@vu.nl.

Coursebook

For the course, we will be using the following coursebook:

Drucker, Johanna. 2021. *The Digital Humanities Coursebook: An Introduction to Digital Methods for Research and Scholarship*. Routledge.

Available at https://vu.on.worldcat.org/oclc/1236262568

Specific chapters are referred to in the weekly reading list in the modules page.

Assessment

- **Project portfolio (40%):**
  - A documentation of the workflow on GitHub (Combination of Individual and Teamwork, 10%) (LO3, LO4, LO5)
  - A poster presentation in the final week (Teamwork, 30%) (LO2, LO4 & LO5)
- **Critical skills, Engagement & Participation 60%):**
  - Weekly, student-led discussions and presentations in class based on the readings (Teamwork, 10%) (LO1, LO2, LO5)
  - Final paper, on TestVision (Individual, 50%) (LO1, LO2 & LO4)

Communication (e-mail)
All communications will take place via email. It is your responsibility to check your inbox daily.

Library

In order to obtain access to the electronic resources of the library and to borrow books, your student card must be registered at the main desk of the VU-Library located on the first floor. Check here how. Via the Library website you can learn how to search for electronic publication as well as how to borrow hard copies.

Contact

Dr Lorella Viola (coordinator): l.viola@vu.nl

Timetable

Classes will be on Tuesdays from 11:00-12:45 (theory), on Thursdays from 11:00-12:45 (practice). For the current timetable always check https://rooster.vu.nl/schedule

Attendance

Classes and preparation are mandatory, which means that an 80% attendance rate is required to obtain the credits for this course. Please contact the coordinator in case of illness or other impediments to attend.

Study load

This course has a study load of 6 ECTS. One ECT is equal to 28 hours of study, so this makes a total of 168 hours: classes: 30-40 hours; preparation and assignments: 16 hours per week (on average) for 7 weeks.

Code of conduct and use of GenAI

Students are expected to maintain academic integrity and respect in all communications and coursework. Plagiarism and dishonesty in any form will be addressed according to university policies. Use of GenAI for this course must be disclosed according to the following criteria:

Level	Qualification	Permitted AI use	Student disclosure
1	No AI	No AI tools was used to produce, revise, translate, or paraphrase any submitted content.	AI disclosure required; assessment design provides assurance
2	AI (or any other program) for editing	AI (or any other program) was used for support of spelling, syntaxis, and/or translation.	Confirm that no AI-generated text is included. Disclosure of editing and/or translation program.
3	AI for research/study	Brainstorming, outlining, summary, feedback, heuristics.	Disclosure of program(s) used with what purpose + upload chatlogs and prompts

Course evaluation
Students will receive an evaluation form (end of the course). It is anonymous. Please take a few minutes to complete it as it is a very important tool to ensure high quality teaching.

Synthetic overview of the course

TUESDAYS 11:00 – 12:45 DH THEORY, REFLECTIONS, DISCUSSIONS				THURSDAYS 11:00 – 12:45 METHODS, TOOLS, PROJECT WORK			
WEEK	DATE	INSTRUCTOR	TOPIC	WEEK	DATE	INSTRUCTOR	TOPIC
1	31/03/2026	Lorella Viola & Dries Daems	PART I: Introduction to the course PART II: Overview of the field, key concepts and methods	1	02/04/2026	Lorella Viola & Dries Daems	PART I: Group formation, datasets distribution & self-enrolment PART II: GitHub
2	07/04/2026	Lorella Viola	PART I: Data, Digitisation, and Quantitative methods in the Humanities PART II: Student-led discussions (groups 1-2)	2	09/04/2026	Lorella Viola	PART I: Data creation PART II: Teamwork dataset exploration & RQ
3	14/04/2026	Dries Daems	PART I: Spatial Humanities PART II: Student-led discussions (groups 3-4)	3	16/04/2026	Dries Daems	Lab: Spatial Humanities with GIS Teamwork on team projects
4	21/04/2026	Lorella Viola	PART I: Computational text analysis PART II: Student-led discussions (groups 5-6)	4	23/04/2026	Lorella Viola	Lab: Computational text analysis with MALLET Teamwork on team projects
5	05/5/2026	NO CLASS	NO CLASS	5	07/05/2026	Lorella Viola & Dries Daems	Team projects presentations
6	12/05/2026	Dries Daems	PART I: Network Analysis for DH PART II: LAB: Network Analysis with GEPHI	6	14/05/2026	NO CLASS	NO CLASS
7	19/05/2026	Lorella Viola & Dries Daems	Poster presentations	7	21/05/2026	FINAL EXAM	FINAL EXAM

Please check the detailed content descriptions of the modules on Canvas.

Assessment

- **Project portfolio (40%):**
  - A documentation of the workflow on GitHub (Combination of Individual and Teamwork, 10%) (LO3, LO4, LO5)
  - A poster presentation in the final week (Teamwork, 30%) (LO2, LO4 & LO5)
- **Critical skills, Engagement & Participation 60%):**
  - Weekly, student-led discussions and presentations in class based on the readings (Teamwork, 10%) (LO1, LO2, LO5)
  - Final paper on TestVision (Individual, 50%) (LO1, LO2 & LO4)

Assignments

Assignment 1: Team Project portfolio (40%)
Students will create a digital humanities project addressing a topic related to current DH debates. In teams, students will have to devise a research statement and develop an Action Plan following the SMART principles (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Realistic and Timely). This assignment is a portfolio of several assignments, described in detail here below.

The documentation of the workflow on GitHub. The workflow should be fully documented on GitHub. If you are not familiar with this collaborative platform, please take some time to get yourself acquainted with it. There is much self-training material available online, for example here. The documentation should also clearly describe the data-set that you are using (i.e., provenance, relevance to your research question, limitations, challenges, availability), the method, the software/tool(s), each step of the workflow, including the justification of why you took the steps you took (and not others). The project description must contain a well-defined research question (RQ), a thesis statement, a description of the dataset, an action plan and a team chart. The relevance of the RQ should be based on a minimum of 3 articles/books on the topic. The thesis statement is the solution/answer to the RQ that you want to investigate. The dataset you will use to answer/investigate your RQ should be problematized (e.g., what are the advantages and limitations of the dataset?). This space documents the entire research process. It should describe the team members (i.e., composition, backgrounds, academic disciplines, etc.), clearly state deliverables and deadlines, foreseen and actual challenges and opportunities, potential pitfalls, means of collaborations and communications, frequency of meetings, division in work packages, timeline.

A poster presentation in the final week. Each team will deliver a poster and present it in the final week. The presentation should clearly describe the research context, the research question, gaps in the field, relevance, the dataset, the workflow, and the results.

This assignment will be assessed against ALL the following criteria:

- Quality of the research (including thesis statement, action plan and team chart);

- Relevance of the topic to current DH debates;
- Quality of the literature;
- Action plan against the SMART principles;
- Quality of the poster;
- Quality of the project documentation;
- Quality of the dataset description;
- Knowledge and critical understanding of the components of a DH workflow.

Assignment 2: Critical skills, Engagement & Participation (60%)

Active participation is a crucial component of this course and students are expected to attend all classes and actively participate in class discussions, group work and other activities. Regular engagement in class discussion will also strengthen your understanding of the course materials and improve your performance in the course's assignments. Every week, 1 team will prepare a 10-minute presentation based on the weekly readings (to rotate among teams). In these presentations, teams should (briefly) summarize the week's readings and (more extensively) critically analyze the key contributions and key arguments of the readings. The non-presenting teams will provide feedback to the presenting teams, while collectively everyone will participate in the discussion. These reflective exercises are intended to develop everyone's critical reading and feedback skills; they will also facilitate the discussion and help the instructors gauge how the readings contribute to a good understanding of the week's topic. Both presenting and non-presenting teams will receive a grade. Students will be assessed against the following criteria:

- Presenting team: Overall quality of the presentation (i.e., clarity, understanding, critical engagement, division of labour);
- Non-presenting teams: Overall quality of the feedback (i.e., engagement, constructive comments)
- Everyone: Active and critical engagement in the discussions

The final paper. The final exam (max. 1,500 words) will be an individual self-reflection report serving as a critical exercise to assess your experience of working on a DH project within an interdisciplinary research team. You should describe what you learned from this experience, from both an educational and personal point of view, clarifying how you, the team and the plan evolved throughout the process, things you would have done differently retrospectively and things that really worked, how this experience compares with your previous teamwork experiences, etc. The final exam will be on TestVision on campus.

Grades

Examinations are assessed with grades on the scale 0.0 – 10.0, accurate to one decimal place, where a 5.5 is the lowest pass grade.

Dutch grading system:

Grade	***Meaning***
10	Outstanding
9	Very good
8	Good
7	More than satisfactory
6	Satisfactory
5	Almost satisfactory
4	Unsatisfactory
3	Very unsatisfactory
2	Poor
1	Very poor

Self-learning tutorials and online tools (this list is not exhaustive)

http://libguides.vu.nl.vu-nl.idm.oclc.org/en/libsearch

https://programminghistorian.org/en/

https://medium.com/dh-tools-for-beginners

https://github.com/OpenRefine/OpenRefine/wiki/Screencasts

https://openrefine.org/

https://hdlab.stanford.edu/palladio/

https://nodegoat.net/

https://fromthepage.com/landing

https://pitt.libguides.com/textmining/preprocessing/

https://gephi.org/

https://www.laurenceanthony.net/software/antconc/

https://www2.fgw.vu.nl/werkbanken/dighum/dh/dh-introduction.php

List of required* and recommended readings

The list may be adjusted during the course following current developments in the field (on Canvas). Compulsory and recommended weekly readings will be posted on Canvas.

Berry, David. 2014. 'Post-Digital Humanities: Computation and Cultural Critique in the Arts and Humanities'. *EDUCAUSE Review* 49 (3): 22–26.

Bodenhamer, David J., John Corrigan, and Trevor M. Harris, eds. 2010. *The Spatial Humanities: GIS and the Future of Humanities Scholarship*. Spatial Humanities. Bloomington: Indiana University Press.

Borgman, Christine L. 2015. *Big Data, Little Data, No Data: Scholarship in the Networked World*. 1 online resource (xxv, 383 pages) vols. Cambridge, Massachusetts: The MIT Press. http://www.books24x7.com/marc.asp?bookid=82612.

Brughmans, T., & Peeples, M. A. (2023). *Network Science in Archaeology*. Cambridge University Press

Crawford, Kate. 2021. *Atlas of AI: Power, Politics, and the Planetary Costs of Artificial Intelligence.* Yale University Press.

*DH@VU. n.d. 'Digital Humanities Workbench'. Accessed 23 April 2024. https://www2.fgw.vu.nl/werkbanken/dighum/dh/dh-introduction.php.

*Drucker, Johanna. 2015. 'Graphical Approaches to the Digital Humanities'. In *A New Companion to Digital Humanities*, 238–50. John Wiley & Sons, Ltd : Chichester, UK.

*———. 2020. *Visualization and Interpretation: Humanistic Approaches to Display*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: The MIT Press.

*———. 2021. *The Digital Humanities Coursebook: An Introduction to Digital Methods for Research and Scholarship*. Routledge. https://vu.on.worldcat.org/oclc/1236262568.

*Dunn, S. (2017). Praxes of "The Human" and "The Digital": Spatial Humanities and the Digitization of Place. *GeoHumanities*, *3*(1), 88–107. https://doi.org/10.1080/2373566X.2016.1245107

Engelhardt, Claudia, Katarzyna Biernacka, Aoife Coffey, Ronald Cornet, Alina Danciu, Yuri Demchenko, Stephen Downes, et al. 2022. *D7.4 How to Be FAIR with Your Data. A Teaching and Training Handbook for Higher Education Institutions* (version V1.2 DRAFT). Zenodo. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.5905866.

Eubanks, Virginia. 2018. *Automating Inequality. How High-Tech Tools Profile, Police, and Punish the Poor.* St. Martin's Publishing Group.

*Falkowitz, Robert. 2020. 'Visualizing Uncertainty'. *This View of Service Management...*, 15 January 2020. https://www.3cs.ch/visualizing-uncertainty/.

Flanders, Julia, and Fotis Jannidis. 2015. 'Data Modeling'. In *A New Companion to Digital Humanities*, 229–37. Wiley-Blackwell. https://doi.org/10.1002/9781118680605.ch16.

*———. 2018. *The Shape of Data in Digital Humanities: Modeling Texts and Text-Based Resources*. Routledge. https://vu.on.worldcat.org/oclc/1066193909.

*Gaver, William W., Jacob Beaver, and Steve Benford. 2003. 'Ambiguity as a Resource for Design'. In *Proceedings of the Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems - CHI '03*, 233. Ft. Lauderdale, Florida, USA: ACM Press. https://doi.org/10.1145/642611.642653.

*Gitelman, Lisa, ed. 2013. *'Raw Data' Is an Oxymoron*. Infrastructures Series. Cambridge, Massachusetts ; London, England: The MIT Press.

*Gold, Matthew K., and Lauren Klein F. 2019. '"Introduction" in "Debates in the Digital Humanities 2019"'. Debates in the Digital Humanities. 2019. https://dhdebates.gc.cuny.edu/read/untitled-f2acf72c-a469-49d8-be35-67f9ac1e3a60/section/0cd11777-7d1b-4f2c-8fdf-4704e827c2c2.

Hughes, Lorna, Panos Constantopoulos, and Costis Dallas. 2015. 'Digital Methods in the Humanities'. In *A New Companion to Digital Humanities*, edited by Susan Schreibman, Ray Siemens, and John Unsworth, 150–70. John Wiley & Sons, Ltd. https://doi.org/10.1002/9781118680605.ch11.

*Le Deuff, Olivier. 2018. *Digital Humanities: History and Development*. http://public.eblib.com/choice/publicfullrecord.aspx?p=5349048.

*Noble, Safiya Umoja. 2018. *Algorithms of Oppression: How Search Engines Reinforce Racism*. *Algorithms of Oppression*. New York University Press. https://doi.org/10.18574/9781479833641.

*———. 2019. 'Gender and Cultural Analytics: Finding or Making Stereotypes?' In *Debates in the Digital Humanities*, edited by Matthew K. Gold and Lauren Klein. Minneapolis: Univ of Minnesota Press. https://dhdebates.gc.cuny.edu/read/untitled-f2acf72c-a469-49d8-be35-67f9ac1e3a60/section/5aafe7fe-db7e-4ec1-935f-09d8028a2687\#ch02.

*Nodegoat. 2017. 'Formulating Ambiguity in a Database'. Nodegoat. 2017. https://nodegoat.net/blog.s/21/formulating-ambiguity-in-a-database.

*Risam, Roopika. 2015. 'Beyond the Margins: Intersectionality and the Digital Humanities'. *Digital Humanities Quarterly* 009 (2).

*Sánchez, Roberto Therón, Alejandro Benito Santos, Rodrigo Santamaría Vicente, and Antonio Losada Gómez. 2019. 'Towards an Uncertainty-Aware Visualization in the Digital Humanities'. *Informatics* 6 (3): 31. https://doi.org/10.3390/informatics6030031.

*Ströbel, Phillip Benjamin, Simon Clematide, and Martin Volk. 2020. 'How Much Data Do You Need? About the Creation of a Ground Truth for Black Letter and the Effectiveness of Neural OCR'. In *Proceedings of The 12th Language Resources and Evaluation Conference*, 3551–59. Marseille, France: European Language Resources Association. https://www.aclweb.org/anthology/2020.lrec-1.436.

*Tarleton Gillespie. 2024. 'Generative AI and the politics of visibility'. *Big Data & Society*. https://journals-sagepub-com.vu-nl.idm.oclc.org/doi/epub/10.1177/20539517241252131.Links to an external site.

*Tarleton, Gillespie. 2014. 'The Relevance of Algorithms', in Tarleton Gillespie, Pablo J. Boczkowski, and Kirsten A. Foot (eds), *Media Technologies: Essays on Communication, Materiality, and Society* (Cambridge, MA, 2014; online edn, MIT

Press Scholarship Online, 18 Sept. 2014), https://doi.org/10.7551/mitpress/9780262525374.003.0009

*Viola, Lorella. 2021. 'Keynote: The Importance of Being Digital'. In *HistoInformatics2021 Workshop - 6th International Workshop on Computational History. Co-Located with JCDL2021*. University of Illinois. https://sites.google.com/view/histoinformatics2021workshop/home?authuser=0.

———. 2023. *The Humanities in the Digital: Beyond Critical Digital Humanities*. S.l.: Palgrave Macmillan.

*Viola, Lorella, and M. Antonio Fiscarelli. 2021. 'From Digitised Sources to Digital Data: Behind the Scenes of (Critically) Enriching a Digital Heritage Collection'. In *Proceedings of the International Conference Collect and Connect: Archives and Collections in a Digital Age*, edited by Andreas Weber, Maarten Heerlien, Eulàlia Gassó Miracle, and Katherine Wolstencroft, 2810:51–64. CEUR – Workshops Proceedings. ttp://ceur-ws.org/Vol-2810/paper5.pdf.

Viola, Lorella, and Paul Spence, eds. 2023. *Multilingual Digital Humanities*. Digital Research in the Arts and Humanities. Abingdon, Oxon New York, NY: Routledge.

*Viola, Lorella, and Jaap Verheul. 2020. 'Mining Ethnicity: Discourse-Driven Topic Modelling of Immigrant Discourses in the USA, 1898–1920'. *Digital Scholarship in the Humanities* 35 (4): 921–43. https://doi.org/10.1093/llc/fqz068.

*Windhager, Florian, Saminu Salisu, and Eva Mayr. 2019. 'Exhibiting Uncertainty: Visualizing Data Quality Indicators for Cultural Collections'. *Informatics* 6 (3): 29. https://doi.org/10.3390/informatics6030029.

*Wuttke, Ulrike. 2019. '"Here Be Dragons": Open Access to Research Data in the Humanities', April. https://doi.org/10.5281/ZENODO.2630155.